

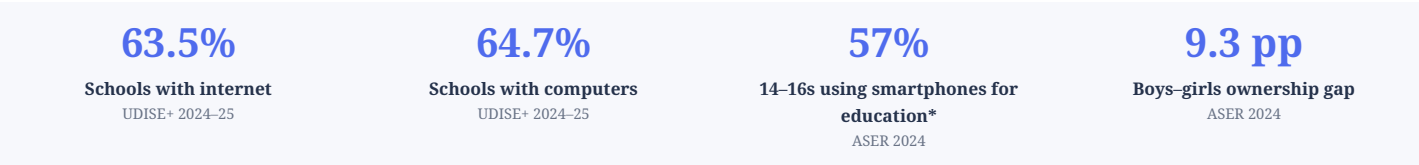
India's Digital Education Readiness

Access is expanding faster than equitable, learning-focused use

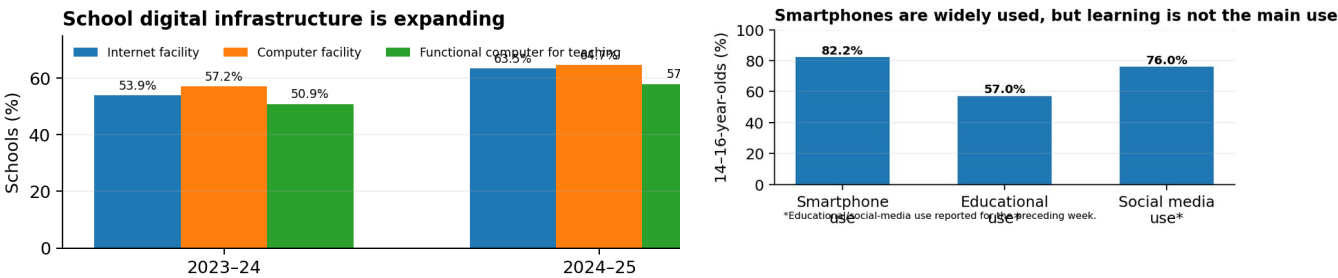
EXECUTIVE SUMMARY India's digital education ecosystem is becoming more connected: UDISE+ shows the share of schools with internet facilities rising from 53.9% in 2023–24 to 63.5% in 2024–25. Yet household access does not automatically translate into learning use. ASER 2024 found that 82.2% of rural 14–16-year-olds knew how to use a smartphone, but only 57% of those users reported an educational activity in the previous week. The evidence points to a second-stage challenge: turning connectivity into inclusive, safe and learning-oriented digital participation.

BACKGROUND & CONTEXT

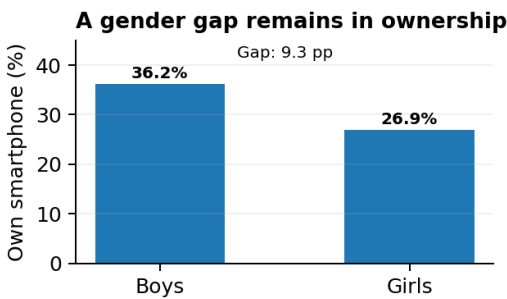
Digital tools can widen access to educational content, especially through platforms such as DIKSHA and PM e-VIDYA. However, the digital divide is not only about whether a device or internet connection exists; it also involves quality of school infrastructure, individual skills, ownership, gender differences and how technology is actually used. This report therefore combines school-level UDISE+ infrastructure data with rural household evidence from ASER 2024.



DATA ANALYSIS & TRENDS



School infrastructure improved across all three measures. Internet access increased by 9.6 percentage points, while computer availability rose by 7.5 points. The rise is meaningful, but roughly 36.5% of schools still lacked internet access in 2024–25, showing that infrastructure coverage is not yet universal. At the learner level, ASER 2024 shows a different pattern: smartphone capability is high, but educational use trails general use. This suggests that access and skills need to be paired with relevant content, teacher support and purposeful learning practices.



KEY FINDINGS

- Connectivity is improving quickly: internet-equipped schools rose from 792,992 to 933,987 in one year.
- The remaining infrastructure gap is material: 536,486 schools were still without internet in 2024–25.
- Digital capability is not the same as learning impact: 57% reported educational smartphone use, versus 76% social-media use.
- Gender equity remains a concern: smartphone ownership was 36.2% for boys versus 26.9% for girls.

SOCIAL IMPACT / IMPLICATIONS

- Governments: prioritize last-mile school connectivity and functional teaching devices, not only installation.
- Schools & teachers: integrate digital resources into lessons and build practical digital-safety skills.
- NGOs & communities: target girls and low-access households with shared-device, mentoring and local-language initiatives.
- Students: use smartphones for structured learning, verification of information and safe participation—not only consumption.

HOW AI ASSISTED THE ANALYSIS

- Research support: AI helped identify a focused, data-rich topic and locate relevant official reports.
- Summarization: AI condensed long UDISE+, ASER and government material into decision-relevant evidence.
- Analysis support: AI calculated percentage-point changes, comparisons and gaps from cited source data.
- Report preparation: AI supported structure, wording and visual selection; statistics were checked against original sources.

CONCLUSION

India is moving from a connectivity problem toward a digital-learning quality problem. School internet and computer coverage improved sharply in 2024–25, while ASER shows that young people already possess substantial smartphone skills. The next priority is therefore equitable access plus purposeful use: stronger school infrastructure, teacher capacity, gender-responsive access and learning-focused digital content can convert digital reach into measurable educational and social impact.

SOURCES

Ministry of Education, Government of India — UDISE+ Report 2024–25, infrastructure tables. <https://dse1.education.gov.in/en/statistics> (2025).

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ASER Centre / Pratham — Annual Status of Education Report 2024, national findings and digital literacy. <https://asercentre.org/aser-2024/> (2025).

Government of India — PM e-VIDYA overview and DIKSHA. <https://pmevidya.education.gov.in/> (accessed 2026).

**ASER educational/social-media use refers to the preceding week among 14–16-year-olds who reported knowing how to use a smartphone. Percentages for UDISE+ are calculated from school counts in the cited official tables; percentage-point changes are calculated from those values.*